hottest field in technology?' It pointed to AlexNet's victory as the moment when 'people started to pay attention, not just within the AI community but across the technology industry as a whole'. The article was illustrated with an image of a robotic hand holding up a photo of a cat.[5]

All those cat images that tech giants had been harvesting from across the world, without paying a penny to either users or tax collectors, turned out to be incredibly valuable. The AI race was on, and the competitors were running on cat images. At the same time that AlexNet was preparing for the ImageNet challenge, Google too was training *its* AI on cat images, and even created a dedicated cat-image-generating AI called the Meow Generator.[6] The technology developed by recognising cute kittens was later deployed for more predatory purposes. For example, Israel relied on it to create the Red Wolf, Blue Wolf and Wolf Pack apps used by Israeli soldiers for facial recognition of Palestinians in the Occupied Territories.[7] The ability to recognise cat images also led to the algorithms Iran uses to automatically recognise unveiled women and enforce its hijab laws. As explained in chapter 8, massive amounts of data are required to train machine-learning algorithms. Without millions of cat images uploaded and annotated for free by people across the world, it would not have been possible to train the AlexNet algorithm or the Meow Generator, which in turn served as the template for subsequent AIs with far-reaching economic, political and military potential.[8]

Just as in the early nineteenth century the effort to build railways was pioneered by private entrepreneurs, so in the early twenty-first century private corporations were the initial main competitors in the AI race. The executives of Google, Facebook, Alibaba and Baidu saw the value of recognising cat images before the presidents and generals did. The second eureka moment, when the presidents and generals caught on to what was happening, occurred in mid-March 2016. It was the aforementioned victory of Google's AlphaGo over Lee Sedol. Whereas AlexNet's achievement was largely ignored by politicians, AlphaGo's triumph sent shock waves through government offices, especially in east Asia. In China and neighbouring countries go is a cultural treasure and considered ideal training for aspiring strategists and policy makers. In March 2016, or so the mythology of AI would have it, the Chinese government realised that the age of AI had begun.[9]